

India's 12 million-odd self-help groups (SHGs) is considered to be the world's largest microfinancing project. And 88 per cent of these SHGs have an all-women membership. The Economic Survey 2022-23 estimated that the SHG Bank Linkage Project covers 142 million families with saving deposits of Rs 47,240 crore. It is also the woman head of the households that sundry governments—at the Centre and in the states—are entrusting direct benefit transfers with, in the knowledge that they will put the money to judicious use. Add more women to the workforce, and the country's GDP will go up by a whole percentage point—to 8 per cent—by 2030, according to a recent Barclays report.

You are beginning to see more women in the rarefied environs of corporate India as well. Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw is an undisputed colossus here, her brewery-to-biotech journey the stuff of corporate legend. And to think when she started her business out of a garage in her Bangalore home, interviewees would walk in asking to see the MD and be disappointed to see a 'chit of a girl' sitting behind the desk wanting to hire them.

There's Falguni Nayar, too, who wanted to embark on an entrepreneurial journey before she completed her own half century in life. Nykaa, the omnichannel beauty retail venture that she founded, is now among the first women-owned enterprises in India to join the billion-dollar unicorn league.

THE INDUSTRY OF WOMEN

Yet, women own only 20 per cent of the enterprises in the country, and most of them micro units, as a report by NITI Aayog in October 2022 revealed. This, when just two years earlier, a study by the Boston Consulting Group discovered that businesses founded by women are known to be more inclusive in their work culture, employ 3x more women and generate 10 per cent more cumulative revenue.

But if they cannot be entrepreneurs, a growing number of women are using the corporate ladder to reach for the sky. Like Sindhu Gangadharan, senior vice-president & MD, SAP Labs India, for whom success has nothing to do with gender. "It does not matter if you are a woman or a man. You know your stuff, you do it," she says. Glass ceilings, noted conservation architect Abha Narain Lambah tells you, are in your head. Union Bank of India MD & CEO A. Manimekhalai agrees wholeheartedly. "The glass ceiling is within you. You break it within you, and you get out of it," she says.

But barriers aren't always glass ceilings, real or imagined. Ask the corporate heiresses—Isha Ambani

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